leader, made China's position clear: 'When the time comes, we certainly will settle accounts with them [the Indians].'[9] And, according to Bruce Riedel, one of American's leading experts on US security as well as South Asian issues, '[p]robably as early as 1959, Mao decided that he would have to take firm action against Nehru'.[10]

Zhao Weiwen, a South Asian analyst at the Ministry of State Security, China's premier intelligence agency, wrote after the war in 1962 that 'India ardently hoped to continue England's legacy in Tibet' and that Nehru himself 'harboured a sort of dark mentality'. Those factors, Zhao argued, led Nehru to demonstrate an 'irresolute attitude' in 1959. And that 'dark mentality', US-China scholar John Garver quotes him as saying, led Nehru to give free rein to 'anti-China forces' in an attempt to foment unrest in Tibet to 'throw off the jurisdiction of China's central government'.[11]

According to Garver, Mao was also present at the same meeting as Deng in March 1959, and the Chairman said that India 'was doing bad things in Tibet' and therefore had to be dealt with. Mao, however, told the assembled members of the inner circle of the Chinese leadership that China should not condemn India openly for the time being. Instead, India would be given enough rope to hang itself, *quo xingbuyi bi zibii*, literally 'to do evil deeds frequently brings ruin to the evil doer'.[12] China was waiting for the right moment to 'deal' with India. But first, it needed precise and accurate intelligence from across the border.

Findings by Nicholas Eftimiades, an expert on China's intelligence operations, reveals that the Chinese began sending agents into the NEFA and other areas two years before the military offensive. 'The PLA gathered facts on India's order of battle, terrain features, and military strategy through agents planted among road gangs, porters and muleteers working in border areas.' These agents, Eftimiades states, 'later guided PLA forces across the area during offensive operations… junior PLA commanders—disguised as Tibetans—had reconnoitred their future area of operation'.[13]

'Two years before the military offensive' began in October 1962 means at least a year before the Forward Policy was conceived, which makes it hard to argue that India's moves in the area provoked China to attack. Furthermore, the date, 20 October 1962, for the final assault after years of preparations was carefully chosen because it would coincide with the Cuban missile crisis, which the Chinese knew about beforehand through